

RESEARCH ARTICLE

The syntax of Italian *col cavolo* and *un cavolo*: Between emphatic negation and utterance minimisation

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Received: 31 March 2025; **Revised:** 27 November 2025; **Accepted:** 28 November 2025

Keywords: emphatic negation; left periphery; objection; polarity licensing; utterance minimisation

Abstract

I discuss two colloquial Italian idioms expressing respectively emphatic negation and objection, *col cavolo* (lit. ‘with the cabbage’) and *un cavolo* (lit. ‘a cabbage’). Despite superficial similarities, they represent two very different strategies at syntactic, semantic, and pragmatic level. *Col cavolo* belongs to a class of non-verbal polar predicates selecting a clausal complement and expressing the speaker’s degree of strength of sincerity towards the proposition (Repp 2013). *Col cavolo* expresses high commitment to $\neg p$: it is base-generated in the left periphery, as confirmed by its limited polarity-licensing abilities and impossibility of agreement with a TP-level negative PolP. Instead, *un cavolo* is a metalinguistic objector (Martins 2020), an echoic responsive move (Farkas & Bruce 2010); it originates as a vulgar minimiser and can function as an ‘utterance minimiser’, predicating minimal relevance of the associate and rejecting it globally rather than reversing its truth conditions. Finally, I compare *col cavolo* with similar cross-linguistic expressions, and offer a generalisation for left-peripheral negators: those participating in a movement or agreement chain with the TP-level PolP have full semantic and polarity-licensing capabilities, while base-generated ones, being non-local to the lower proposition, only license weak polarity items and yield double negation with a lower negative PolP.

1. Introduction

In this paper I provide a syntactic, semantic, and pragmatic analysis of two idiomatic expressions of denial or objection in colloquial Italian, *col cavolo* (1) and *un cavolo* (2):¹

¹ I follow the Leipzig Glossing Rules (<https://www.eva.mpg.de/lingua/pdf/Glossing-Rules.pdf>), though to varying degrees of detail, to avoid unnecessary specificity. Further abbreviations: DEP = deponent; EXPL = expletive; IMPRS = impersonal; QUD = question under discussion; X.NEG = *xuj* negation.

While *col cavolo/un cavolo* are used/understood throughout Italy, for the record I am a native speaker of Italian born and bred in Romagna (Northeast Italy); when in need of judgements, I have consulted with speakers from the same region. I have also received grammaticality judgements from an anonymous reviewer.

- (1) **Co-l cavolo** che Gianni ha visto Giacomo.
 with-the cabbage COMP Gianni has seen Giacomo
 'Gianni has definitely not seen Giacomo.'
- (2) A: Sono migliore di te.
 be.PRS.1SG better than you
 'I am better than you.'
- B: (Migliore) **un cavolo!**
 better a cabbage
 '(Better) my eye!'

I argue that, despite superficial appearances (a 'denial' function of sorts and the occurrence of the same lexical item), these expressions are distinct both structurally and functionally, and that they represent two very different strategies. *Col cavolo* is a focal, non-verbal predicate of emphatic polarity, the negative counterpart of a class of Italian expressions of emphatic affirmation like *certo che*, lit. 'certain that', which select for full clauses and convey the speaker's epistemic attitude towards the propositional content of the lower clause; while emphatic affirmations express high commitment to *p*, *col cavolo* conveys high commitment to $\neg p$. On the other hand, *un cavolo* is what is known in the literature as a 'metalinguistic negator', which rejects or objects to an antecedent utterance, comparable to the English ones discussed by Horn (1985, 1989) and exemplified below:

- (3) A: John is a genius.
 B: **Like hell** John is a genius!
- (4) A: I read all of Chomsky's writings.
 B: **My eye** you did!

What they do have in common, and what I will argue they have in common with other left-peripheral negators (LPNs) and objectors, is the expression of the speaker's commitment and attitude towards the proposition/utterance. Moreover, the superficial commonality of incorporating the same vulgar element is not unmotivated: *cavolo* represents a low-scalar endpoint, which is originally employed in both cases to convey minimal speaker commitment to *p* (hence, high commitment to $\neg p$) or opposition to including the proposition into the Common Ground.

Relatedly, I propose that *un cavolo* derives its use as an utterance objector from an illocutionary extension of its use as a vulgar minimiser, along with other members of the same class of Italian indefinite-like expressions which can function as what I call UTTERANCE MINIMISERS, by having their scalar semantics recast at discourse level as conveying minimal

Another reviewer objects to the use of the term '(left-peripheral) negator' for elements whose negativity is put in doubt throughout the paper, especially for *un cavolo*. In the following I will indeed replace the term 'metalinguistic negator' with 'objector' or 'utterance minimiser' for *un cavolo*. But I would like to maintain the term 'negator' for *col cavolo* and its cross-linguistic counterparts. To begin with, under a Hornian-Reppian 'duality of use' approach to the ambiguity of negation, a pragmatically oriented negator is *still* a negator, its negative force is simply specialised to apply to something other than (or in addition to) the assertion (cf. Repp's 'illocutionary negation'). Moreover, *col cavolo* and its counterparts are not metalinguistic in any sense: they apply to a proposition, not to an utterance, and their limitations and features are arguably due to their non-locality to the lower material. With this very important caveat, I should like to maintain the term LPN as a correct characterisation of the *col cavolo* class.

interest in, or relevance of, the utterance they modify – not necessarily implying falsehood or reversal of truth conditions, then. This is taken to derive from a conventionalised implicature from minimisation to (pragmatic) irrelevance, a development which is compared to a similar cline in Latin.

The second purpose of this article is to provide a typology of the syntax of left-peripheral negators based on the comparison between the Italian cases and similar expressions described in previous literature. In particular, I will hypothesise that the interpretation of the negative import and licensing capabilities of LPNs are a function of their derivational history, and depends on whether they establish a relation to the lower TP-level PolP (by either movement or Agree).

The article is organised as follows. In [Section 2](#) I provide an overview of the concepts of external and metalinguistic negation, *FALSUM*, and of existing analyses of the syntactic and semantic-pragmatic properties of idiomatic negators and LPNs. [Section 3](#) offers an analysis of *col cavolo* as a negative, focal non-verbal predicate reversing the polarity of the lower clause and expressing high speaker commitment against its inclusion in the Common Ground. [Section 4](#) is an analysis of *un cavolo* as an utterance minimiser, a pragmatic, utterance-level extension of the low-scalar import of its use as a vulgar minimiser. [Section 5](#) summarises the similarities and differences between the two negators and lays out a structural typology of LPNs and utterance minimisers. [Section 6](#) concludes.

2. Clarifying the Terminology: External, Metalinguistic, and Emphatic Negation

Before discussing *col cavolo* and *un cavolo*, it is necessary to present a brief background on the notion of emphatic negation and to define in which sense similar illocutionary operators are considered negative in the previous literature. This will allow us to correctly identify the features of the two constructions under exam and their relevance for cross-linguistic analysis.

2.1. Metalinguistic negation and *FALSUM*

The concept of external negation opens Horn's (1985) work on the pragmatic ambiguity of metalinguistic negation. Consider (5), originally due to Bertrand Russell, and (6):

- (5) The king of France is not bald – there is no king of France.
- (6) John is not tall – he is colossal.

In (5), negation does not negate the predicate *bald*, but the presupposition that a king of France exists; in (6), negation cancels the implicature that *tall* means 'moderately tall': a 'descriptive' understanding of negation would be contradictory, since one cannot be colossal without also being tall. Negation thus appears to be ambiguous, capable of denying either asserted or non-asserted (implicated, presupposed, etc.) content. Horn argues that the ambiguity can be resolved in the following way: 'negation [...] is not SEMANTICALLY ambiguous. Rather, we are dealing with a PRAGMATIC ambiguity, a built-in duality of use' (Horn 1985: 132; emphasis in the original). Other uses which Horn notes are difficult to lead back to a logic or semantic ambiguity are those which object only to formal aspects of an utterance (his *She's not Lizzie, if you please—she's Her Imperial Majesty*). For these cases, Horn recovers Ducrot's (1972) concept of METALINGUISTIC NEGATION, defined as 'a means for objecting to a previous utterance on any grounds whatsoever, including [...] the way it was

pronounced' (Horn 1985: 134). Thus, by virtue of its association with the pragmatic rather than semantic level, metalinguistic negation conveys an OBJECTION to an utterance, rather than the truth of a proposition. This corresponds to 'a use distinction: [negation] can be a descriptive truth-functional operator, taking a proposition p into a proposition *not- p* , or a metalinguistic operator which can be glossed "I object to u ", where u is crucially a linguistic utterance rather than an abstract proposition' (Horn 1985: 136).

The idea that metalinguistic negation is a pragmatic device rather than a semantic operator accounts for further differences with descriptive negation. As Karttunen and Peters (1979: 46–47) originally noted, metalinguistic uses of negation fail to license polarity items:

- (7) John didn't MANAGE to solve {some/*any} problems—they were quite easy for him to do.

Horn comments that since negation in (7) targets not the assertion but the implicature carried by *manage*, it is truth-conditionally and semantically inert, and as such, it is not a suitable licenser for *any*.

The idea that negation may be recast as a discourse/illocutionary operator was reprised by Repp (2009, 2013), who proposes a discourse operator for 'illocutionary negation' which she calls FALSUM (8).² This operator has similar semantics to Romero and Han's (2004: 627) VERUM (cf. fn. 2), the difference being that whereas under VERUM the proposition is a member of the Common Ground, FALSUM conveys that it is not:

- (8) $\llbracket \text{FALSUM} \rrbracket^x = \lambda p_{\langle s, t \rangle} \lambda w. \forall w' \in \text{Epi}_x(w) [\forall w'' \in \text{Conv}_x(w') [p \notin \text{CG}_{w''}]]$

In prose, given all the worlds w' which conform to x 's epistemic state (knowledge) in w , and all the worlds w'' which conform to x 's conversational goals in w' , it is for sure that the proposition p is not in the Common Ground in w'' . Repp proposes that the two operators express what she calls 'degrees of strength of sincerity'. Sincerity conditions, a reflex of the Maxim of Quality requiring the speaker to believe that the proposition expressed is true, are a gradable property; while VERUM conveys that the speaker's degree of sincerity is high, FALSUM conveys that the degree is zero. Thus, while Repp's formula does not include a negative operator, the contribution of FALSUM is essentially equivalent to negation, but it is applied at the level of the illocution rather than at the propositional level (what Repp calls 'illocutionary negation').³

² FALSUM is meant as the polar opposite of Verum Focus, a phenomenon originally described by Höhle (1992) in German and exemplified below with English:

- (i) A: John did not write an essay. (Verum)
B: He DID write an essay!
(ii) A: John wrote an essay. (FALSUM)
B: He did NOT write an essay!

Whether VERUM corresponds to ordinary Roothian Focus applied to the set of truth values or to a separate lexical operator is a debated point; for an overview in the 'lexical operator' spirit, cf. Gutzmann et al. (2020).

³ An anonymous reviewer objects that FALSUM may well have truth-conditional effects: *John did NOT come* is unmarkedly understood as negating that John came. This is not problematic in my view: as stressed by Carston (1996) and Geurts (1998), the proposition/utterance may be rejected because of wrong implicatures, presuppositions, or for formal reasons, but nothing prevents rejecting it because it is false. This latter effect is truth-conditionally indistinguishable from 'descriptive' negation.

Thus, the speaker who uses *FALSUM* objects to the addition of *p* to the Common Ground on the basis of the fact that it cannot be felicitously *UTTERED* (cf. Horn's understanding of metalinguistic negation as operating at the level of the utterance). But crucially, while it may have the same logic effect of negation at the truth-conditional level, it will not correspond to negation semantically (for instance in terms of licensing capabilities) as it applies at a different level than the propositional level at which descriptive negation applies, which is why *FALSUM*/metalinguistic negation cannot license NPIs either (English expresses *FALSUM* by stressing the negative marker, cf. fn. 2):

- (9) *I did NOT steal any cookies.

2.2. The syntax of 'metalinguistic negators'

In line with Horn's observation that languages do not lexicalise a separate external negator, Repp's *FALSUM* is lexically identical to the standard negator. Yet, languages often possess idiomatic expressions which convey metalinguistic negation or *FALSUM*. Martins (2014: 645–649) discusses peripheral metalinguistic negators in European Portuguese, like *uma ova*, lit. 'a fish's roe' (note that *viver* is an intransitive verb, which excludes that *uma ova* is a direct object):

- (10) Ele viveu sempre em Paris *uma ova*.
 he lived always in Paris a fish's.roe
 'Like hell, he has always lived in Paris.'

These expressions can appear on their own in fragments:

- (11) A: Ele pagou o jantar, não pagou?
 he paid the dinner not paid
 'He paid for the dinner, didn't he?'
 B: Uma ova!
 'Like hell he did!'

They can co-occur with standard negation yielding a double negation reading:

- (12) Não bebe *uma ova*.
 not drinks a fish's.roe
 'Like hell he doesn't drink.'

They have wide scope (e.g., they scope over both conjuncts in a sequence of coordinated events):

- (13) Eles casaram e tiveram um filho *uma ova*,
 they married and had.3SG a baby a fish's.roe
 eles casaram porque tiveram um filho.
 they married because had.3SG a baby
 'They didn't get married and have a baby, they got married because they had a baby.'

Martins (2014: 651) takes these and other features as evidence that these elements are externally merged in the left periphery. When *uma ova* is sentence-initial no movement operation takes place, while when it is sentence-final IP-topicalisation follows External Merge of *uma ova* in SpecCP (I adapt and simplify Martins' 2014: 653 analysis for brevity):

- (14) (*uma ova*) O João deu um carro à Maria (*uma ova*)
 a fish's.roe the João gave a car to Maria a fish's.roe
 'Like hell/no way João gave Mary a car.'
- (15) [CP *uma ova* [C' [ΣP [Σ' [TP [T' deu [VP ...
- (16) [TopP [ΣP O João_n deu_i um carro à Maria] [Top' [CP *uma ova* [C' t_{ΣP}]]]]

Martins relates the connection between metalinguistic negation and the CP to Farkas and Bruce's (2010) distinction between initiating and responding assertions. The former have 'absolute' polarity features, while the latter have 'relative' ones, which means that, while with initiating assertions the polarity is independent of the discourse context, with responding ones (including Verum/FALSUM) the polar features interact with the polarity of the utterance they react to. Farkas and Bruce (2010: 106–107) propose two kinds of polarity features for responding moves, [*same*] for confirmation and [*reverse*] for opposition. Martins (2014: 664) proposes a further one, inspired by Horn's (1985) classic definition of metalinguistic negation: the feature [*objection*], which is carried by metalinguistic negators. These examples illustrate that metalinguistic negators can coexist with an independent expression of (positive or negative) polarity in the lower proposition, causing a double negation effect. Martins (2014: 665) takes 'the exclusive features of responding assertions, that is, relative polarity features, to be grammatically encoded in the CP domain, whereas absolute polarity features are encoded in ΣP, the topmost functional projection in the IP domain' (cf. Laka Mugarza 1990). Martins thus advocates for a double syntactic exponence of polarity, with different functions and interpretations. These observations can be tied to the assumption (Speas & Tenny 2003, Ramchand & Svenonius 2014 a.o.) that the CP-layer is the locus of the interface between syntax and discourse. It is thus fitting that a discourse-managing operator like metalinguistic negation should be preferentially expressed in this clausal area.

Martins (2020) points out another difference between standard negation and metalinguistic negative markers, coherent with their left-peripheral nature: the latter take wide scope over the lower material, as also discussed by Lasnik (1972: 50–51). Consider her examples:

- (17) (a) He is not in jail because he lied.
 (b) [Reason>Neg] It is because he lied that he is not in jail.
 (c) [Neg>Reason] It is not because he lied that he is in jail.
- (18) (a) Like hell he is in jail because he lied.
 (b) #[Reason>Neg] It is because he lied that he is not in jail.
 (c) [Neg>Reason] It is not because he lied that he is in jail.

While the standard negator allows for scope ambiguity with respect to the reason adjunct in (17), the negative idiomatic phrase in (18) only allows for the reading in which negation scopes over the reason adjunct.

2.3. Left-peripheral negation is not (necessarily) metalinguistic

Despite Martins' observations, it is important to stress that not all expressions of left-peripheral negation are metalinguistic in nature. Several languages possess idiomatic negators which are left-peripheral but do not present the hallmarks of metalinguistic negation. Moreover, some languages have been argued in the literature to express not only idiomatic or emphatic negation, but even standard negation in dedicated left-peripheral projections. Well-known cases are Gbe languages, for whose negation Aboh (2010) proposes a left peripheral position just below FocP. Another is Modern Irish, which has negative complementisers which McCloskey (2017) derives from Agree with a TP-level [iNeg]-bearing PolP.

Moreover, there are further cases of expressive or emphatic left-peripheral negation which, though idiomatic, do not have any presuppositional or metalinguistic import, can license (some) polarity-sensitive items, and are truth-conditionally equivalent to sentential negation. I will review three which are relevant to the present discussion: British/Irish English *fuck*-inversion (Sailor 2017, 2020), Russian *xuj*-negation (Erschler 2023), and Irish Demonic Negation (McCloskey 2009, 2018, D'Antuono 2024a).

2.3.1. *Fuck*-inversion

Fuck-inversion is exemplified below (Sailor 2017: 88):

- (19) They are all wearing kilts, but will I fuck be wearing one of them.

This construction is characterised by subject-verb inversion, similar to negative inversion proper, followed by a taboo term. Like negative inversion proper, *fuck*-inversion is downward-entailing (Sailor 2017: 91) and licenses polarity items, even strong ones like *until* (Sailor 2017: 92):⁴

- (20) Will he fuck vote for independence → Will he fuck vote for radical independence.
(21) Will I fuck be leaving until they pay me my money.

Sailor also notes that *fuck*-inversion differs from metalinguistic negators. To begin with, it can be used in the absence of an overt linguistic antecedent (Sailor 2017: 95):

- (22) It's St. Patrick's Day tomorrow, but will I fuck be wearing green

It can also be used to answer information-seeking questions, similarly to regular negative inversion and again differently from metalinguistic negators (Sailor 2017: 96):

- (23) Q: Is it sunny outside?
A: In no way is it/Is it fuck (sunny outside)! (cf. #Like hell it is sunny outside!)

⁴ Sailor (2017: 93) also excludes that *fuck*-inversion corresponds to a 'squattive' (Horn 2001, Postal 2004), since these can notoriously appear without the standard negative marker without any difference in meaning (i), while *fuck*-inversion is incompatible with the presence of overt negation, even when it constitutes a denial of a previous clause:

(i) John didn't do jack shit to help us ↔ John did jack shit to help us.
(ii) *Isn't he fuck a nice guy ↔ Is he fuck a nice guy!
(iii) A: John didn't have a drop to drink last night.
B: *Didn't he fuck!

Sailor proposes that the taboo term does not instantiate the negative component of the construction; rather, it (partially) realises the emphatic component: *fuck* is a polarity-sensitive focus particle, to which Sailor assigns the Spec position of the ν P-peripheral FocP (Belletti 2004). Negative inversion is triggered by the presence of a null negative operator *à la* Zeijlstra (2004), which moves to the left-peripheral SpecFocP from the TP-level PolP, causing the auxiliary to raise to Foc^o (hence the incompatibility with a lower expression of negation, cf. fn. 4), similarly to Haegeman's (2000) account of 'overt' negative inversion in terms of the Negative Criterion (e.g., *Never have I seen such a thing*):

- (24) [_{FocP} OP_[NEG] will_{[T[NEG]+Foc]} [_{TP} [_{DP} he] will_{[T[NEG]]} [_{PolP} ~~OP_[NEG]~~ Pol [_{FocP} fuck Foc
[_{νP} ...]]

2.3.2. *Xuj* negation in Russian

Erschler (2023: 2) discusses the Russian vulgar negator *xuj*:

- (25) <XUJ> Vasja <XUJ> pošël <*XUJ> na rabotu segodnja.
X.NEG Vasya went on work.ACC today
'Vasya didn't go to work today.'

Xuj gives rise to double negation when it co-occurs with the standard negative marker (Erschler 2023: 3):

- (26) XUJ Vasja ne pojdët na rabotu.
X.NEG Vasya NEG will.go on work.ACC
'It is not the case that Vasya won't go to work.'

Xuj licenses polarity items (27), but crucially not *ni*-words (28), which Erschler (2023: 10–12) argues to be Negative Concord Items (NCIs)⁵ which are licensed locally by a null Neg^o

⁵ A rather standard definition of NCI is given below:

- (i) Negative Concord Item (Giannakidou 2006: 328, adapted)
An expression α is an NCI iff:
(a) α can be used in structures containing sentential negation or another α -expression yielding a reading equivalent to one logical negation; and
(b) α can provide a negative fragment answer.

Zeijlstra (2004) proposes that Negative Concord is a form of Agree between the uninterpretable [*uNeg*] feature of the indefinite and the [*iNeg*] feature of the (possibly null) negative operator. It is thus often understood as a syntactic phenomenon, as opposed to the mostly semantic explanations given for the licensing of polarity items. Note, though, that Erschler considers NCIs to be licensed semantically by Op_[NEG] rather than via syntactic Agree. NCI behaviour is exemplified below with Italian:

- (ii) (a) Non ho visto nessuno.
NEG have.1SG seen nobody
'I saw nobody.'
(b) Q: Chi hai visto?
who have.2SG seen
Who did you see?
A: Nessuno.
'Nobody.'

operator in the lower PolP rather than with *xuj* (cf. (29)); thus, *xuj* is incapable of licensing negative concord items, but it can license (weak) polarity-sensitive items (Erschler 2023: 6–7):

- (27) **XUJ** segodnja **kto** čego ponjal.
 X.NEG today who what understood
 ‘No one understood anything today.’
- (28) *<**XUJ**> ni-kto ni-čego segodnja <**XUJ**> ponjal.
 X.NEG NEG-who NEG-what today X.NEG understood
 intended: ‘No one understood anything today.’

Erschler proposes the structure (29), where the lower PolP hosts a negative operator responsible for negating the clause (and for licensing NCIs like *ni*-words); *xuj*, which is associated with another negative operator, is ‘segregated’ in a higher left-peripheral PolP:

- (29) [_{PolP} Op^{NEG}_{*xuj*} **XUJ** [...] [_{PolP} Op^{NEG}_{*ne*} [_{TP} [_{DP} *Vasya*] T [_{NegP} *ne*_[Neg°] +*pojdet*_[Asp°-v°-V°]]
 [_{AspP} [_{VP} ...

Thus, *xuj* and the standard negative operator occupy separate, independent projections, which explains the obligatory double-negation reading when they co-occur.

2.3.3. Irish ‘Demonic Negation’

D’Antuono (2024a) offers an account of Irish ‘Demonic Negation’ (named after McCloskey 2009, 2018):

- (30) (a) Dheamhan a mbuaileann sé duine ar bith.
 Demon a^N hit-PRS 3SG person on earth
 ‘He does not hit anyone.’
- (b) Dheamhan duine (ar bith) a bhuail-eann sé.
 demon person on earth a^L hit-PRS 3SG
 ‘Not a (single) person does he hit.’

D’Antuono proposes that *dheamhan*, originally meaning ‘(to a) demon’, grammaticalised as an emphatic negator and is externally merged in a left-peripheral PolP, as indicated by the ‘indirect’ complementiser *a^N* – distinguished by the nasalisation of the initial consonant of the following verb – which following McCloskey (2002) diagnoses base-generation in the left-periphery. Additionally, *dheamhan* can be followed by a constituent of any grammatical category – the object DP *duine (ar bith)* in (30b) – in this instance with a scalar effect comparable to Germanic Negative Inversion (i.e., *Not a single person did I see*). In this case, the ‘direct’ complementiser *a^L* appears, which causes lenition of the initial consonant of the following verb and is a diagnostic of movement to the left periphery (McCloskey 2002), indicating that the constituent to the right of Demonic Negation has been raised to the left-periphery. D’Antuono (2024a) offers the following analysis for the two versions of Demonic Negation, which he calls respectively ‘Bare Demonic Negation’ and ‘Demonic Negation plus XP’:

- (31) [_{PolP} dheamhan [_{FocP} Foc [_{FinP} a^N [_{PolP} mbuaileann [_{TP} sé T [_{VP} v [_{VP} duine ar bith
 V]]]]]]]]

- (32) [_{PolP} dheamhan [_{FocP} [duine ar bith]_{DP} Foc [_{FinP} a^L [_{PolP} bhuaileann [_{TP} sé T [_{VP} v [_{tDP} V]]]]]]]]]

Like *fuck*-inversion and *xuj*, *dheamhan* can also license polarity items, like *ar bith*, both in the left periphery and in the lower clause. Moreover, it can co-occur with a lower sentential negation yielding double negation, again like *xuj*:

- (33) Dheamhan mórán duine nach raibh ann.
 demon many person COMP.NEG was there
 'Not many people were not there.'

Importantly, Demonic Negation is not limited to the expression of metalinguistic or external negation: it is not a presuppositional negator or a marker of denial. D'Antuono concludes that Demonic Negation is a full-fledged negative operator, with the complete palette of readings that are available to standard negation and with polarity-licensing capabilities, and not a metalinguistic negator.

It is clear from this brief overview that the idiomatic or emphatic nature of expressive negators does not automatically correlate with an 'external', 'special', or 'metalinguistic' semantic-pragmatic specialisation, let alone with left-peripheral position. What the association with the left periphery does appear to correlate with is an emphatic, evidential, or epistemic import, and the expression of a strong attitude of the speaker towards the proposition. In what follows, I will discuss how the two Italian expressions fare with respect to the typology just expounded and to the analyses existing in the previous literature.

3. The Syntax of *Col Cavolo*

The main topic of this section is the expression *col cavolo* (henceforth CC, lit. 'with the cabbage'). The relevant construction is repeated below; (34b), a counterpart of Sailor's (2017: 95) example, illustrates that CC is not a 'presuppositional' negator, since it does not have to constitute a denial of a previous statement⁶:

- (34) (a) **Col cavolo** che Gianni ha visto Giacomo.
 CC COMP Gianni has seen Giacomo
 'Gianni has definitely not seen Giacomo.'
 (b) Domani è San Patrizio, ma **col cavolo** che metto il verde.
 tomorrow is St. Patrick but CC COMP put.PRS.1SG the green
 'It's St. Patrick's Day tomorrow, but will I fuck be wearing green.'

Thus, CC does not have to constitute a REVERSING ACTION in Farkas and Bruce's (2010) terms: it is not specialised as a responsive move to a previous utterance (though it is very commonly used in denials due to its emphatic import). Prosodically, CC bears focal prominence. It is

⁶ Of course, a modicum of discourse activation is necessary to accommodate for emphasis, and to some extent even for negation itself. This is not necessarily a feature of metalinguistic negation *per se*: Givón (1978) observes that the marked status of negation with respect to affirmation entails that some context is always required for negation to be pragmatically felicitous (even *I am not a linguist* requires some more context than the affirmative *I am a linguist*).

followed by a clause headed by the complementiser *che*.⁷ *Col cavolo* can also be used in negative fragments:

- (35) Q: Laveresti i piatti?
wash.COND.2SG the dishes
'Would you wash the dishes?'
A: Col cavolo!
'Hell no!'

Semantically, CC conveys a strong commitment on the part of the speaker to the truth of $\neg p$ (or, conversely, to the falsehood of p), p being the proposition of the lower clause.

It is tempting to associate CC with FocP, not least because of the pitch prominence that is associated with it. There are several facts which seem to support this analysis. Firstly, it is incompatible with another focalised constituent (under any interpretation):

- (36) (*GIANNI), col cavolo (*GIANNI) che ho visto.
Gianni CC Gianni COMP have.PRS.1SG seen
'It is Gianni whom I have not seen.'

Notably, for me it is also incompatible with Foci in the lower clause (which aligns with the fact that CC takes obligatory wide scope, cf. (58)):

- (37) *Col cavolo che ho visto GIANNI (non Luca).
CC COMP have.1SG seen Gianni not Luca
'I have definitely not seen GIANNI (not Luca).'

Instead, it is compatible with topics, or with CLLD constituents in general, and can occur below them (38a) and also below Scene-setting adverbials (38b):

- (38) (a) Gianni, col cavolo che l=ho visto.
Gianni CC COMP CL.3MSG=have.1SG seen
'As for Gianni, I have definitely not seen him.'

⁷ CC can also be sentence-final, in which case no complementiser is present:

- (i) Gianni ha visto Giacomo **col cavolo**.
Gianni has seen Giacomo CC
'Gianni has definitely not seen Giacomo.'

Some speakers find (i) unacceptable. I would never produce a sentence-final CC myself, but I have occasionally heard it. A search in the Paisà Corpus (<https://www.corpusitaliano.it/it/index.html>) returns a of couple such cases:

- (ii) risponde ne-l giro di pochi minuti che partecipa **col cavolo**.
answer.PRS.3SG in-the turn of few minutes COMP participates CC
'he answers within a few minutes that he sure won't participate.'
(<http://www.autoblog.it/tag/formula+1+2010>)

- (iii) a-l Festival ci vengono **col cavolo**
at-the Festival there come.PRS.3PL CC
'they will definitely not come to the Festival'
(<http://www.soundsblog.it/post/9233/sanremo-2010-noemi-malika-ayane-irene-grandi-e-simone-cristicchi-confermati-in-arrivo-anche-morgan-sonohra-e-valerio-scanu>)

- (b) A-l mare, col cavolo che ci vado.
 at-the sea CC COMP there go.PRS.1SG
 'I will not go to the beach!'

Finally, the very fact that it can be used in fragment answers also seems to conform to a focal analysis for CC, given Merchant's (2004) suggestion that fragments are moved to SpecFocP.

To clarify the syntax of CC, it will be useful to examine a class of Italian non-verbal predicates which bear a considerable similarity to the expressions under exam.

3.1. *Italian non-verbal predicates*

The non-verbal predicates I mean to examine are those mentioned by Poletto and Zanuttini (2013: 133) in their study of *sì che/no che* sentences in Italian. These are adjectives like *certo*, *chiaro*, *ovvio* ('certain, clear, obvious'), followed by a clausal complement.

- (39) (a) **Certo** che lo sapeva.
 Certain COMP it knew.3SG
 'Of course he knew it.'
 (b) **Certo** che non lo sapeva.
 certain COMP NEG it knew.3SG
 'Of course he did not know it.'

These elements also share the peculiar focal features of CC ((40)–(42) are adaptations of the authors' (10)–(12), (16), and (47)).⁸ They are incompatible with the presence of a focussed constituent:

- (40) ***Certo** che IL CAFFÈ beve.
 certain COMP the coffee drinks.3SG.PRS
 'Of course he drinks coffee.'

They are compatible with CLLD constituents (41) and provide fragment answers (42):

- (41) **Di libri**, certo che ne legge tanti.
 of books certain COMP of.them reads many
 'Books, he definitely reads many.'

⁸ There is an apparent difference with CC. At first sight, non-verbal predicates seem to be acceptable in copular clefts:

- (i) (È) certo che Gianni è un bravo linguista.
 be.PRS.3SG certain COMP Gianni is a good linguist
 'It is certain that Gianni is a good linguist.'

Nonetheless, the addition of the copula significantly alters the pragmatic-semantic import of the utterance. Interestingly, what is lost with the addition of the copula is precisely the commitment, or the epistemic attitude of the speaker. *Certo che p* is an emphatic assertion that the proposition that follows is true according to the speaker who utters it: the contribution of *certo* relates to the speaker's degree of sincerity. *È certo che p*, on the other hand, is an objective remark: it merely predicates that *p* being true is a certain thing. Hence, *certo che* and *È certo che* do not form a minimal pair.

- (42) Q: Lo sapeva?
 it knew.3SG
 'Did he know it?'
 A: Certo.
 certain
 'Of course.'

Poletto and Zanuttini's (2013: 124) main empirical object are *sì che/no che* sentences:

- (43) Q: È poi arrivato Gianni?
 is then arrived Gianni
 'Did Gianni arrive in the end?'
 A: Sì che è arrivato.
 yes COMP is arrived
 'Of course he arrived.'
 A': No che non è arrivato.
 no COMP NEG is arrived
 'Of course he didn't arrive.'

These negators present the same familiar features of CC and of other non-verbal predicates: they are emphatic, they are incompatible with the copula and with focussed constituents, and they are compatible with CLLD constituents.

Poletto and Zanuttini (2013) consider the status of the complementisers in this type of structure to be unclear. In Rizzi's (1997) cartography, *che* is the complementiser sitting in the head of the highest projection of the left periphery, ForceP. Nonetheless, they claim that this cannot be correct for the case at hand. Consider (44) (Poletto & Zanuttini 2013: 130):

- (44) [_{ForceP} *che* [_{TopP} (left dislocated element) [_{FocP} *sì/no* [_{FinP} [_{TP} ...]]]]]

If answer particles are assumed to occupy SpecFocP in Italian, the fact that this position is found below *che* (and below CLLD constituents) would derive the wrong surface structure. Moreover, CLLD constituents, which are taken to occur below ForceP (Benincà & Poletto 2004), may occur below the complementiser in *sì che/no che* sentences (Poletto & Zanuttini 2013: 131). I believe this to be the case for CC sentences as well:

- (45) (a) No che di libri non ne legge tanti.
 no COMP of books NEG of.them reads many
 'He does not read many books at all.'
 (b) Col cavolo che di libri ne legge tanti.
 CC COMP of books of.them reads many
 'He does not read many books at all.'

Thus, both CC and *no che* appear to sit above ForceP. A crucial difference between *no che* sentences and CC is that the former REQUIRE the presence of negation in the lower clause:

- (46) No che *(non) è venuto.
 no COMP NEG is come
 'Of course he didn't come.'

For the combined reasons given above, Poletto and Zanuttini propose that *sì che/no che* sentences are biclausal, i.e., the particles lie above ForceP – the topmost projection – because like CC they scope over a full clause. They propose the following structure for *sì che/no che* (Poletto & Zanuttini 2013: 136):

- (47) $no_i \dots [_{ForceP} OP_i [_{Force^\circ} che [_{TopP} [_{FocP} [_{PolP} e_i [_{Pol^\circ} non [TP \dots]]]]]]]$
- 

The authors posit a PolP (Laka Mugarza's 1990 ΣP) whose Spec is occupied by an empty category *e*, which is valued as negative by a higher null negative operator in ForceP, in turn connecting *no* to the clause introduced by *che*. When this happens,

the head of PolP is realized as *non*; otherwise, the head of PolP is null. This is the reason why the co-occurrence of *no* and *non* gives rise to single instance of negation, and not to double negation: *no* binds an operator which has the same value as the head of PolP, *non*, resulting in a single chain. (Poletto & Zanuttini 2013: 136)

This also explains why focussed constituents are not allowed with *sì che/no che* sentences: the operator chain of Focus fronting would create a minimality violation with the polarity chain, the authors note.

As for the position of the answer particle in *sì che/no che* sentences, Poletto and Zanuttini (2013: 135, adapted) propose that it occupies the Spec of the PolP of the higher clause, possibly moving to its SpecFocP.

- (48) $[_{ForceP} [_{TopP} [_{FocP} sì_i [_{PolP} sì_i [_{ForceP} OP_i [_{Force^\circ} che [_{TopP} [_{FocP} [_{PolP} e_i [TP \dots]]]]]]]]]$
- 

The polar chain with the lower negation represents a crucial difference between *no che* sentences and CC which, along with the aforementioned similarities, will further inform the structural analysis of CC.

3.2. Back to *col cavolo*

A first, obvious difference between *no che* sentences and CC is that the latter is compatible with both a positive and a negative lower clause (in contrast to *fuck*-inversion). If CC scopes over a negative clause, double negation occurs:

- (49) (a) Col cavolo che vengo.
 CC COMP come.PRS.1SG
 'I will not come!'

 (b) Col cavolo che non vengo!
 CC COMP NEG come.PRS.1SG
 'I won't not come!'

It thus appears that the polarity of the clause introduced by *che* is independent from the negative contribution of CC. No simultaneous binding of the polar variable in PolP seems to

be at work between the lower *non* and CC in (49b), and the result is that the two negations cancel each other out, as with *Demonic Negation* and *xuj*. As noted by Poletto and Zanuttini, non-verbal predicates like *certo* may also take a negative lower clause. It seems, then, that with CC there is no ‘continuous’ chain with the lower PolP.

In Poletto and Zanuttini’s analysis, the purpose of the negative operator in ForceP is to relate the answer particle in the higher clause to the polarity of the lower one. But in the case of CC, no such relation appears to exist: as illustrated, CC cannot agree with the lower negation, but only yields double negation in composition with it. On the other hand, if no agreement chain is formed between the variable in SpecPolP and the operator in SpecForceP, what prevents a focussed constituent from moving to the Spec of the lower FocP? This movement would not induce any minimality effect. Everything falls out if, as argued, CC itself sits in a focus projection: CC is incompatible with focussed constituents because it occupies Focus.⁹

Can we say that CC is extracted from the lower clause, like the negative operator in *fuck*-inversion? As mentioned in fn. 7, CC can also appear rightmost, at least for some speakers. It could then be suggested that CC is extracted from a lower position, perhaps an adjunct position. This analysis does not appear to be satisfactory, though. First of all, for some speakers the sentence-final version is unavailable (fn. 7). This unavailability would be bewildering if CC were extracted from that position. Moreover, when a constituent is Focus-fronted to the left periphery in Italian no complementiser appears before it, differently from clefts (Belletti 2008). CC does not allow for the presence of the copula, which suggests that it is a different construction (and conversely requires the presence of the complementiser, which is impossible for Focus-fronted constituents in Italian, cf. (50b)):

- (50) (a) *(È) Gianni che ho visto.
Is Gianni COMP have.PRS.1SG seen
‘It is Gianni that I saw.’
(b) GIANNI (*che) ho visto.
Gianni COMP have.PRS.1SG seen
‘I saw GIANNI (not Luca).’
(c) (*È) col cavolo che ho visto Gianni.
it.is CC COMP have.PRS.1SG seen Gianni
‘I did not see Gianni!’

Moreover, CC sentences do not appear to have the corrective or mirative interpretation that is available in Italian to constituents that are focus-fronted (Bianchi & Bocci 2012, Bianchi et al. 2016) or clefted. For instance, in (50b) the focalisation of *Gianni* creates a set of alternatives (Rooth 1992), to the effect that *Gianni* is understood as the entity which makes the proposition true out of a given set. Additionally, if CC is truly extracted from a lower

⁹ One may wonder why CC also disallows a Focus in the lower clause. Note that this effect is not limited to CC in Italian: it is difficult to have two Foci even in (i):

- (i) *?GIANNI ricorda che LUCA non è venuto.
Gianni remembers that Luca NEG is come
‘GIANNI remembers that LUCA did not come.’

The two Foci are in two different clauses, with the matrix moreover having a non-bridge verb. This ban is perhaps due to the fact that, as noted by Bianchi and Bocci (2012), Italian Foci in situ, corrective ones in particular, are still fronted at LF, at which point Gianni and Luca compete for the same position.

position, it loses its idiomatic meaning. Consider the examples in (51), with an adjunct concerning a literal cabbage in (51a), and CC in (51b):

- (51) (a) Co-1 cavolo_i, Luca mi ha raccontato che Gianni sarebbe venuto t_i,
 with-the cabbage Luca me has told COMP Gianni be.COND.3SG come
 non co-i broccoli.
 NEG with-the broccoli
 ‘Luca told me that Gianni would come with the cabbage, not with broccoli.’
- (b) #Col cavolo_i che Luca mi ha raccontato che Gianni
 CC COMP Luca me has told COMP Gianni
 sarebbe venuto t_i.
 be.COND.3SG come
 ‘Luca told me that Gianni would not come for anything on earth.’

(51a), albeit slightly burdened by successive-cyclic movement, is acceptable in Italian with an extraction from the lower clause. (51b) relates to the previous observation that the emphasis of CC is associated with an attitude towards *p*, which in turn requires an association with an epistemic centre or point of view (Potts 2007). In (51b), the negative force of CC can only apply to THE SPEAKER’s attitude. It cannot mean that GIANNI had no intention whatsoever of coming, as would be expected if *col cavolo* were possibly/optionally generated as a negative adjunct in the lower clause (thus associated with *Gianni’s* epistemic state) and later moved to the high SpecFocP. In this connection, consider (52):

- (52) Col cavolo che Gianni sarebbe venuto.
 CC COMP Gianni be.COND.3SG come
 ‘Gianni would definitely not come.’

In (52) CC can emphasise GIANNI’s intention of not coming,¹⁰ with the propositional attitude attributed to the subject. This is the reading which is not available for (51b), where Gianni’s coming is embedded under another clause. Conversely, this interpretation is only possible if CC is embedded, as in (53):

- (53) Luca mi ha raccontato che Gianni, col cavolo che sarebbe venuto.
 Luca me has told COMP Gianni CC COMP be.COND.3SG come
 ‘Luca told me that Gianni would not come for anything on earth.’

This set of properties means that the anchoring (in Speas & Tenny’s 2003 terms) of CC does not have to correspond to the Speaker; it can also be associated with the subject of the clause immediately dominated by CC, but crucially it must be local to it and cannot reconstruct into

¹⁰ The fact that CC cannot associate with the subject in (51b) suggests that for this to happen the subject’s intentionality must be at issue (which it can be in (52), but not in Luca’s episodic relation of a past event in (51b)). This fact, while very interesting, raises non-trivial questions at the interface of syntax and pragmatics. I leave its analysis for future research.

Interestingly, Sailor (2014: 94) observes that a retort (cf. *infra*) such as *nah* also requires involvement of the speaker’s ‘mental state or [their] participation in an event’, and is thus speaker-oriented. Sailor notes that *nah* also requires a special context for the attitude to transit from the speaker to a third party.

an even lower clause. Hence it cannot have $\bar{A}$ -moved to a higher SpecFocP from there. I take this to imply that CC is base-generated in its Spellout position, as proposed by Martins (2014, 2020), Erschler (2023), and D’Antuono (2024a) for their respective expressions. This, in turn, makes it more plausible that, for those speakers who accept it, sentence-final CC also occupies this position in a biclausal structure, with the lower clause moving to a SpecTopP (or GroundP) above the FocP hosting the LPN, as illustrated below¹¹:

(54) Syntax of CC (First alternative)

- (a) [_{ForceP} [_{GroundP} [_{FocP} col cavolo Foc^o [_{ForceP} che [_{TP} Gianni ha visto Giacomo]]]]]
- (b) [_{ForceP} [_{GroundP} [_{TP} Gianni ha visto Giacomo]_i Ground^o [_{FocP} col cavolo Foc^o [_{ForceP} [_{TP} t_i]]]]]]]

(54) makes sense of the focal features of CC, as well as of the clause-externality it shares with other non-verbal predicates and *no che* sentences. Yet, I would like to discuss an interesting alternative analysis, due to an anonymous reviewer. Krifka (2023) proposes a ‘layer of assertions’ model whereby a region exists above ForceP, composed of discourse-managing projections: a Judgement phrase, which hosts evidential modifiers identifying the source of the epistemic attitude towards the proposition (e.g., *apparently*), a Commitment phrase which expresses the (speaker’s) commitment to the lower proposition (German *wirklich*, ‘really’), and a Speech Act phrase which motivates or explains the speech act, or relates it to other ones (German *offen gesagt*, ‘frankly speaking’):

- (55) [_{ActP} *offen gesagt* [_{ComP} *wirklich* [_{JP} *apparently* [_{CP/ForceP} ...

It is natural to associate CC with the ComP, since Krifka himself proposes that other expressions of polar commitment/Verum/FALSUM (like Egyptian Arabic *wallahi*, Mughazy 2003) occupy this position. CC would thus sit in ComP. The CC-final version would be derived by movement of the lower clause to SpecActP, perhaps motivated by the latter’s ‘relational’ function with respect to the Common Ground.

(56) Syntax of CC (Second alternative)

- (a) [_{ActP} [_{ComP} col cavolo [_{JP} [_{ForceP} che [_{TP} Gianni è venuto]]]]]
- (b) [_{ActP} [_{TP} Gianni è venuto] Act^o [_{ComP} col cavolo [_{JP} [_{ForceP} [_{TP} t_{TP}]]]]]

The proposition-externality of ComP allows an alternative explanation of the ‘biclausality’ effect of CC and of other non-verbal predicates. The FocP- and ComP-based analysis are both viable in my view. The latter could also account for the fact that one

¹¹ One may wonder what motivates the association of CC with Focus at the semantic level; what type of set of alternatives is opened, of which CC is a member? Since I propose that LPNs are associated with degrees of strength of sincerity, the relevant set may comprise any lower degrees than that expressed by CC. An alternative analysis may involve an alternative set of propositions – minimally including the proposition with the opposite polarity – as similarly proposed by McCloskey (2018: 3) for the interpretive effect of Demonic Negation, ‘which we might understand in terms of the introduction of an alternative-targeting operator which ranks propositions on a scale of expectedness or surprisal and places the negative proposition at an extreme point on that scale’.

of the few types of elements which may occur after CC are epistemic modifiers, assumed to occur in JP¹²:

- (57) Col cavolo, **secondo** **me**, che Gianni è venuto.
 CC according.to me COMP Gianni is come
 'Gianni did not come, I don't think.'

Yet, I believe that taking CC to sit in a FocP better accounts for the focal features of CC and for its complementarity with other Foci. The fact that CC is low enough to occur below Topics, CLLD constituents, and Scene-setting adverbials (38) also follows more easily from the FocP analysis. In what follows I will adopt (54), while maintaining that (56) is a possible alternative structure.¹³

The clause-external nature of CC is further supported by a parallelism with Martins' (2020) example in (18):

- (58) Col cavolo che è in galera perché ha mentito.
 CC COMP is in jail because has lied
 (a) [Neg>Reason] It is not because he lied that he is in jail.
 (b) #[Reason>Neg] It is because he lied that he is not in jail.

That CC cannot scope over the reason adjunct alone further confirms its external position with respect to the lower clause it dominates, as well as the base-generation analysis.

I would like to propose that this is a crucial divide among LPNs: those which are INTERNALLY merged into the left periphery (like negation in *fuck-inversion*) or participate in an Agree chain with the TP-level PolP (like *no che*) have full licensing capabilities, and consequently either require (in the case of Agree, cf. *no che* *(*non*)) or ban (in the case of

¹² The same reviewer observes that vocatives may also interrupt the otherwise strict adjacency between CC and the complementiser (*Col cavolo, Luca, che Gianni è venuto*), in line with Moro's (2011) proposal that the vocative phrase likewise dominates the left periphery. They further wonder why the complementiser is mandatory with CC but not with, e.g., *like hell*. As I will argue, the latter patterns with metalinguistic negators ('utterance minimisers') and is thus remarkably different, both structurally and functionally, from an LPN like CC. As for their question whether a prosodic break occurs with final CC: I think the TP in the two versions has a different prosody, but I do not find that a break is necessary. The prosody of these structures, while interesting, must be left for future research.

¹³ Krifka's (2023) model may also accommodate expressions like *tipo (che)*, brought to my attention by a reviewer:

- (i) A: In spiaggia costava tutto tantissimo.
 'Everything was so expensive at the beach.'
 B: Tipo che anche l'acqua costava più di €5?
 'Like, even water cost more than €5?'
 B': Anche l'acqua costava più di €5, tipo?
 'Even water cost more than €5, like?'

Tipo (lit. 'type') has a distribution similar to CC and other non-verbal predicates, but with an approximative character: it presents the following proposition as potential/likely, or as a passable approximation to the truth. I would say it defines a low commitment (it presents the following proposition as true, but the speaker is perhaps not committed to the details or consequences of their statement). This low commitment allows *tipo* to appear in questions, as in the reviewer's examples, contrary to CC and *certo che*: one can legitimately ask if an approximation of truth can be accepted into the Common Ground, while the high commitment of CC is incompatible with questioning (one cannot be committed to $\neg p$ and at the same time ask if p is true).

movement, cf. *fuck*-inversion) the presence of a negation in the lower clause; those which are base-generated in the left periphery (like CC, *xuj*, and Demonic Negation) only have limited licensing capabilities and yield double negation with a negative lower PolP, to which they are not related by either Agree or movement. In the next subsection I will further argue for this analysis.

3.3. *Col cavolo* and polarity licensing

A classic test for the negativity of a marker is its ability to license polarity-sensitive items. These tests align CC with LPNs like *xuj* and Demonic Negation. Most of the Italian polarity items are NCIs (cf. fn. 5), and CC does not seem to be able to license them:

- (59) **Col cavolo che Gianni ha visto nessuno/niente/nessuno studente.*
 CC COMP Gianni has seen nobody/nothing/no student

This is in line with Erschler's observation that *xuj* cannot license the NCI *ni*-words in Russian. If CC sentences are indeed biclausal, then the ungrammaticality of (59) may be due to the difficulty in licensing NCIs across domains (a consequence of the clause-bound nature of the Agree operation) rather than to the lack of negative import in CC.

There are some Italian idioms which have the distribution of weak NPIs. One is the phrase *alzare un dito*, 'lift a finger'. That *alzare un dito* is a weak NPI is demonstrated by the fact that, apart from negation, it can be licensed by monotone decreasing quantifiers (60a) and in long-distance configurations (60b):

- (60) (a) *Pochi hanno alzato un dito per aiutar-mi.*
 few have.3PL lifted a finger for help-me
 'Few lifted a finger to help me.'
 (b) *Nessuno ricorda che Gianni abbia alzato un dito.*
 nobody remembers that Gianni have.SBJV.3SG lifted a finger
 'Nobody remembers that Gianni lifted a finger.'

Now, *alzare un dito* is acceptable in the scope of CC, and so are other weak elements like *mai*, '(n)ever', just as (weak) PIs are licensed by *xuj* and Demonic Negation:

- (61) (a) *Col cavolo che alzo un dito.*
 CC COMP lift.PRS.1SG a finger
 'I won't lift a finger!'
 (b) *Col cavolo che Gianni è mai stato in Spagna!*
 CC that Gianni is ever been in Spain
 'Gianni has never been to Spain!'

This aligns with the fact that, like *fuck*-inversion, CC is nonveridical (i.e., does not entail the truth of the following proposition, Giannakidou 1998), or in any case monotone decreasing (62):

- (62) *Col cavolo che Gianni ha letto un libro → Col cavolo che Gianni ha letto un romanzo.*
 'John did not read a book → John did not read a novel.'

Regardless of whether it is nonveridicality, downward entailment (Ladusaw 1979), or some other property that licenses weak NPIs, then, it is unsurprising that CC should license them.

Does this prove that CC is not formally negative? Like its cross-linguistic counterparts, CC can indeed be negative (i.e., have the same semantic import as a sentential negator like *non*), with the impossibility of licensing NCIs being due to locality restrictions on Agree. Consider (63), featuring the strong NPI *affatto*, 'at all' (suggested by Matteo Greco, p.c.):

- (63) (a) *Col cavolo che Gianni ha mangiato **affatto**.
 CC COMP Gianni has eaten at.all
 'Gianni definitely did not eat at all.'
 (b) *Pochi sono **affatto** felici.
 few are at.all happy
 '*Few are happy at all.'

Like NCIs, strong NPIs must be licensed LOCALLY by negation (and mere downward monotonicity is insufficient, cf. (63b)), so biclausality suffices to exclude (63a), without this militating for the non-negativity of CC. The polarity licensing facts go in the direction of my own structural analysis; yet, I think that the relevance of the licensing pattern of CC goes beyond this observation. Again, base-generated LPNs like CC and *xuj* have limited licensing capabilities, while those which are related to the lower PolP by Agree or movement, like *no che*, *fuck*-inversion, as well as Irish standard negation, pattern together both in terms of the possibility and interpretation of a lower negation, and in terms of polarity and negative licensing.¹⁴

The generalisation is that when an LPN is base-generated, the semantic effects of its negative import cannot 'reach' into the lower clause: a negator bound to occur in the left periphery by its association with discourse or speaker orientation is non-local to the lower clause UNLESS it is related to its PolP by Agree or movement. Thus, base-generated LPNs can only license those weak elements in their scope for which their properties of nonveridicality and downward monotonicity suffice. LPNs related to the semantically active negation/polarity of the TP-layer, on the other hand, share in its full semantic and licensing capabilities.

4. *Un Cavolo*: Metalinguistic 'Negators' as Utterance Minimisers

Despite superficial similarities, *un cavolo* ('a cabbage', UC) is radically different from CC: it is functionally and pragmatically distinct, syntactically different, and I will conclude that this expression is not even a negator, but rather a vulgar minimiser with its import applied at the level of the utterance. Yet, I believe that its analysis will considerably enrich the

¹⁴ Demonic Negation, which is base-generated, is expected to pattern with CC and *xuj*, but this is difficult to decide due to the absence of NCIs in Irish and to the general weakness of its polarity-sensitive expressions. The double negation facts, though, do align it with CC and *xuj*.

Strong polarity items can notoriously be licensed at long distance in Neg-Raising configurations with 'permeable' CPs selected by certain predicates (*I don't think John is happy AT ALL*). Regardless of whether this is the result of a syntactic 'transportation' of negation from the lower clause or of a semantic-pragmatic inference due to the matrix predicate, what the base-generated CC lacks is precisely the bridging relation with the lower clause, so the absence of a Neg-Raising effect is expected: we have independent evidence of the externality of CC to the lower clause (Section 3.2).

understanding of what ‘metalinguistic negators’ are, and its lexical kinship with CC will be at least in part motivated. UC is exemplified again in (64):

- (64) A: Sono migliore di te.
 be.PRS.1SG better than you
 ‘I am better than you.’
 B: Migliore un cavolo!
 better UC
 ‘Better my eye!’
 B’: Un cavolo!
 ‘My eye!’

In (64), the speaker refuses to allow the interlocutor’s proposition into the Common Ground. (Part of) the interlocutor’s utterance is repeated, and UC either follows or precedes it. UC can also appear in isolation, in which case it works like an emphatic negative answer particle (64B’). Differently from CC, UC can only be used in response to another utterance (65a), or in any case to reject given information (65b), no new lexical material can be added to it (65c), and it cannot answer information-seeking questions, which do not presuppose their answer (65d):

- (65) (a) #Non hai saputo? Gianni è venuto un cavolo!
 not have.2SG known Gianni is come UC
 ‘#Haven’t you heard? Like hell Gianni came!’
 (b) Mi avevano detto che Gianni è venuto. Venuto un cavolo.
 me had.3PL told COMP Gianni is come come UC
 ‘They told me Gianni has come. Like hell he has.’
 (c) A: Gianni è venuto.
 Gianni is come
 ‘Gianni has come.’
 B: #Gianni è venuto in motorino un cavolo!
 Gianni is come in scooter UC
 ‘Like hell Gianni came on a scooter.’
 (d) A: Piove?
 ‘Does it rain?’
 B: #Piove un cavolo!
 ‘#Like hell it rains!’

These features (especially (65a–c)), which Sailor (2014) fittingly terms neophobia, are reminiscent of the conversational moves he calls ‘retorts’ (of which *sì che/no che* sentences appear to be a subcase):

- (66) A: John has eaten kale.
 B: No, he hasn’t!/He has NOT!
 (67) A: John hasn’t eaten kale.
 B: YES, he has!/He has {too/so}!

Retorts are ‘polarity-reversing assertions’ – which is also reminiscent of what CC does. The difference with retorts proper is that CC is not intrinsically responsive (34b); retorts reverse

the polarity of an antecedent, and Sailor claims that they are related to the lower Σ P by movement or by an operator (the similarity with Poletto and Zanuttini's analysis of *no che* and with *fuck*-inversion is apparent):

- (68) [_{PolP} [_{XP} yes] Pol [_{TP} [_{DP} he] has [_{Σ P} ~~XP~~ Σ ...
 (69) [_{PolP} [_{XP} *op*] Pol [_{TP} [_{DP} he] has [_{Σ P} [_{XP} TOO/so] Σ ...

On the other hand, CC is both independent from an antecedent and from the polarity of the lower clause.

Conversely, while being responsive, UC is more 'metalinguistic' than retorts: it does not so much refer to the truth or falsehood of the proposition, rather it objects to an utterance being accepted into the Common Ground. For instance, in the context of (70) John may well be a doctor: (70B) OBJECTS to the utterance on the grounds of the irrelevance of this fact in the face of his incompetence:

- (70) A: Gianni è un dottore.
 Gianni is a doctor
 'Gianni is a doctor.'
 B: Dottore un cavolo! Mi ha fatto una diagnosi sbagliata!
 doctor UC me.DAT has made a diagnosis wrong
 'Doctor my eye! He misdiagnosed me!'

The modifiability of the 'inherited' material from the previous utterance is also limited: the utterance is almost completely opaque (the only elements which can be modified with respect to the antecedent are deictic ones, like 1st and 2nd person pronouns and locative adverbs; for the rest, the preceding utterance is repeated *verbatim*). When only part of the utterance is repeated, it is generally the part with which the speaker disagrees:

- (71) A: Gianni ha comprato questo cappotto per Luca.
 Gianni has bought this coat for Luca
 'Gianni bought this coat for Luca.'
 B: Per Luca un cavolo! L=ha comprato per sé.
 for Luca UC it=has bought for self
 'For Luca my eye! He bought it for himself.'

It has no polarity-licensing capability whatsoever:

- (72) A: Gianni è stato in Spagna.
 'Gianni has been to Spain.'
 B: È (*mai) stato in Spagna un cavolo!
 is ever been in Spain UC
 'Like hell he's (*ever) been to Spain!'

These features of UC confirm that it acts as a metalinguistic objector, rather than as a semantic negator dealing in truth conditions.

This is also confirmed by the fact that the rejected utterance may express no truth conditions at all. Consider the following real-life, spontaneous example (from an episode of the Italian TV

show *Propaganda Live*, La7). An old lady at a demonstration cannot advance because of the crowd and, more insurmountably, because of a barrier. A man tells her *Prego* ('please/I beg you/be my guest'), a fixed expression, to invite her to pass. The old lady answers:

- (73) *Prego un cazzo!*
 please UC
 'I beg you my ass!'

Connectedly, consider (74):

- (74) A: *Vai.*
 'Go.'
 B: *Vai un cavolo!*
 'Go my eye!'

(74B) cannot be interpreted as a negative imperative ('Do not go'), but only as a rejection of the imperative illocution as a whole ('I am not going', 'Do not tell me to go', or something along those lines).

I would like to make a tentative hypothesis at this point. A remarkable aspect of UC is its DP structure, which it shares with other metalinguistic objectors which have a similar distribution and function: *un fico secco* 'a dried fig', *un cappero* 'a caper', *un accidente* 'a disgrace/curse', *un corno* 'a horn', and also with Portuguese and Spanish ones (*uma ova*, *una mierda*, cf. Martins 2020). These items have in common either the fact of being vulgar or that of having a referent that is of little worth or desirability. In fact, they can be taken to be scalar endpoints, with the scale based on intrinsic value or relevance of the referent of the head noun (Zeijlstra 2018). The presence of a determiner, and in particular of the indefinite article *un*, then, is not due to chance; it denotes an atomic, scalar endpoint.¹⁵ The purpose of these expressions is to equate the (conversational/informational) value of the preceding utterance to the lower end of an epistemic scale of relevance, downplaying its communicative or informational value.¹⁶ These utterances are a kind of equative structure: they minimise the contribution of the targeted utterance to a scalar point that is so low that the utterance itself is inferred to be informationally worthless. This scalar or minimising flavour of 'metalinguistic negators' is fundamental for an understanding of their uses and semantics; they are, in a sense, UTTERANCE MINIMISERS.

¹⁵ An anonymous reviewer wonders why the endpoint is marked by the indefinite rather than definite article, given that this endpoint is unique. I believe that scalar endpoints in general *tend* to remain indefinite because they do not establish a discourse referent, but simply represent an abstract minimal quantity, which need not be referred to as definite. Moreover, if the present analysis of UC as deriving from its indefinite use is on the right track, the use of the indefinite article probably reflects the fact that scalar expressions interpreted under negation need in turn to be indefinite so that the exhaustification of the scalar alternatives they activate is not trivial or vacuous (Chierchia 2013). Beyond this 'inheritance' mechanism, nothing would prevent an idiomatic objector or negative expression as such from being definite: English *my eye* is definite, and so is Catalan/Spanish *Rita*, a proper name (Bosch 2024). Even more relevantly, CC itself is definite: 'with *the* cabbage', and so are expressions like *manco per il cavolo*, 'not even for the cabbage' (i.e., 'no chance in hell'). I take this to indirectly strengthen the minimiser-to-objector analysis for UC.

¹⁶ In this respect, cf. Martins' (2020) observation that *nothing* can function in a similar way in English:

- (i) A: He found proofs that clinched the argument.
 B: He found proofs that clinched the argument *nothing*.

As for the syntax of UC, I see two alternatives. One is that, given its (pseudo-)predicative nature, this equative construction is similar to a small clause, where UC is a predicate expressing minimal conversational/informational value of the SubjP, which is occupied by the opaque linguistic material under discussion¹⁷:

- (75) [_{SC} [_{SubjP} migliore] [_{PredP} un cavolo]]

An anonymous reviewer proposes an alternative analysis in terms of Wiltschko's (2021) interactional language model. Similarly to Krifka (2023), Wiltschko (2021) posits an 'interactional spine' above the CP layer, devoted to speaker-addressee interaction (cf. Speas & Tenny 2003) and Common Ground management:

- (76) [_{RespP} *Interacting* [_{GroundAdrP} *Adr-grounding* [_{GroundSpkrP} *Spkr-grounding* [_{CP} *Linking* ...

The reviewer proposes that UC could be associated with GroundSpkrP, where it values a [coincidence] feature as negative, thus objecting to the addition of an antecedent *p* to the Common Ground without asserting its polar opposite, which is what UC does. The copy of the lower material, which conversationally 'belongs' to the addressee, may be assumed to raise to GroundAdrP:

- (77) [_{ResP} [_{GroundAdrP} [_{CP/ForceP} Gianni è venuto] GroundAdr° [_{GroundSpkrP} un cavolo [_{t_{CP/ForceP}}]]]]

The reviewer's suggestion is valuable; perhaps the small clause analysis fares better with respect to the pseudo-predicative nature of the UC construction, as well as with the syntactic opacity of the lower material, which behaves more like inert, quoted metalinguistic material. As with the alternative analysis of CC in (56), I maintain this as a possible alternative for UC.¹⁸

¹⁷ (75) is somewhat agnostically labelled, and problematically symmetric; proposals exist in the literature to the effect that the relation between the subject and predicate is mediated by a functional projection, or derived by movement of the subject above the predicate:

- (i) [_{FP} [_{SubjP} Subj°] F° [_{PredP} Pred°]]

I cannot go into the syntax of small clauses here; cf. Citko (2011) for an overview.

¹⁸ The derivation of UC cannot be analysed as extraction of the material preceding UC with subsequent ellipsis of the remnant under a move-and-delete approach (Merchant 2001, 2004). Indeed, UC can associate with elements which could not be extracted without incurring island violations, as in (ii):

- (i) A: Il ragazzo che viene da-l Trinity è un bravo linguista.
 the boy who comes from-the Trinity is a good linguist
 'The boy from Trinity is a good linguist.'
 B: Da-l Trinity un cavolo! Viene da UCD.
 from-the Trinity UC comes from UCD
 'From Trinity my eye! He's from UCD.'
- (ii) *_{[PP} Dal Trinity] il ragazzo che viene *t_{PP}* è un bravo linguista.
 *_{[PP} From Trinity] the boy *t_{PP}* is a good linguist.'

Space limitations prevent me from discussing these facts, but as noted by a reviewer UC utterances appear to be amenable to Griffiths et al.'s (2023: 160, adapted) analysis of 'reprise fragments':

- (iii) A: Did a neuro or psycholinguist pass by?
 B: Neuro.

The small clause approach is also reminiscent of other cases of ‘Root Small Clauses’ (Progovac 2015: 35), among which ‘*Mad* magazine sentences’ (78) (Akmajian 1984)¹⁹:

- (78) John a doctor?!
 (79) Everybody out!
 (80) Case closed.

These are expressions, often exclamative, associated with Common Ground/QUD negotiation (78), strong illocution (79), or a QUD-terminating assessment (80). UC could be considered as a similar case of Root SC, *modulo* the possibility of quoting full sentential (albeit opaque) material in the SubjP.

I believe that UC is also crucial for an understanding of the inferential nature of linguistic negation. Minimal amounts or minimisation, like scalarity, are often grouped among those features which have some kind of semantic solidarity with or dependency from negation. Yet, negation itself sometimes arises as a consequence of pragmatic inferences. An exemplar case of consolidation of a hyponegative interpretation (understood as a negative interpretation arising in the absence of an overt expression of negation, cf. Horn 2009) is the negative use of Latin *minime* ‘minimally’, the superlative of *parum*, adverbial ‘little’.

- (81) (a) *minime-que miror Clinia hanc si deperit.*
 minimally-and surprise.DEP.1SG Clinia this if pines
 ‘I am not at all surprised that Clinia pines for her.’
 (Terentius, *Heautontimorumenos*, 525)
- (b) *homo minime ambitiosus.*
 man minimally ambitious
 ‘An absolutely unambitious man.’
 (Cicero, *Epistula ad Familiares*, 13)
- (c) *Placet igitur eos dimitti? [...] Minime.*
 likes then 3PL.ACC release.INF.PASS minimally
 ‘Shall we then set them free? Absolutely not!’
 (Sallustius, *De Catilinae Coniuratione*, 51)

Minime can be interpreted as an emphatic, reinforced negation (‘not at all’), also in isolation as a fragment answer. Its original reference to a scalar endpoint can thus be pragmatically maximized to convey emphatic negation. This inference could be explained along the following lines. In the case of fragment answers to *yes-no* questions, the speaker has the chance to give a positive or negative answer. According to the Maxim of Quality, both are preferable to other less informative answers (as long as truth is preserved). In other words,

The authors argue for an *in situ* analysis of the ellipsis process deriving this type of fragment (while not excluding a move-and-delete approach under other circumstances), working around the elided material. This model is particularly inviting for an elliptical analysis of UC. Note that under the interactional approach (and also under a small-clause approach which assumes raising of the SubjP around the PredP, cf. fn. 17) one may assume in any case the raising of the associate to a position to the left of UC prior to ellipsis.

¹⁹ Note that it is easy to continue a *Mad* magazine sentence with UC (*Gianni un dottore?! Dottore un cavolo!*, with ‘doctor’ shifting from the PredP to the SubjP position in the UC ‘answer’ resolving the QUD). Relatedly, an anonymous reviewer wonders whether UC carries an inference that the associate, or its inclusion in the Common Ground, is ‘absurd’. Speakers (among whom myself) do not perceive such an association, but the strong disagreement expressed by UC nicely complements the absurdity flavour of *Mad* magazine sentences.

yes and *no* (or their cross-linguistic counterparts) are the best (most informative) answers to a yes-no question. Other answers, like those expressing uncertainty or ignorance, are only acceptable when the speaker cannot truthfully provide a polar answer. But with *minime*, the speaker comes as close as possible to the brink of negation without expressing it. When one is asked, for instance, if they want something or not, it is quaint to answer that they want it 'minimally'. This almost negative answer is then pushed off the brink by an implicature, which is conventionalised in Latin, to the point that *minime* can substitute for standard negation as an emphatic negator. If you want or believe something to the least conceivable degree, then you most likely do not want or believe it at all, as the implicature goes.

Thus, minimal quantification can be pragmatically maximised – or minimised – to non-existence and, when applied to a sentence, the discourse effect is equated to that of negation proper. When applied to an utterance, as in the case of Italian metalinguistic objectors, it quantifies its communicative relevance as lowest, thus qualifying it as unworthy of inclusion in the Common Ground. Thus, the outer appearance of Italian metalinguistic objectors is not an idiomatic quirk of language, but rather a reflection of their semantic and pragmatic features.

As a confirmation that these items are indeed minimisers of some kind, consider (82):

- (82) (a) Non ho visto un cavolo.
 NEG have.1SG seen a cabbage
 'I haven't seen squat.'
 (b) Non vale un fico secco.
 NEG is.worth a fig dried
 'It isn't worth a farthing.'

These items can be used as arguments and adjuncts in negative sentences in the same capacity as minimisers. More precisely, they belong to the loosely defined category of 'vulgar minimisers' (Postal 2004, Garzonio & Poletto 2008: 65–66) or 'squatitives' (Horn 2001, De Clercq 2011). In Italian, these minimisers are negative in isolation (though they are not grammatical in preverbal position):

- (83) A: Cosa è successo?
 What is happened
 'What happened'?
 B: Un cavolo/Un fico secco.
 'Nothing at all.'
- (84) *Un fico secco potrà fermar-ci.
 a fig dried can.FUT.3SG stop-us
 'Nothing will stop us.'

This unusual behaviour shows that vulgar minimisers, as noted by Larrivée (2021), are amenable neither to the category of NCIs nor to that of NPIs, but are rather situated along a gradient of negativity (for an alternative approach to the grammar of aggressive expressions in Italian in terms of their association with an EvalP, cf. Giorgi & Poletto 2019). These items are not acceptable in downward-entailing contexts, showing that they are not weak NPIs:

- (85) *Pochi studenti hanno letto un cavolo.
 few students have read a cabbage
 'Few students read anything.'

- (86) *A malapena ho visto un fico secco.
 hardly have.1SG seen a fig dried
 ‘I hardly saw anything.’

Yet, they seem fine in long-distance configurations:

- (87) Non ricordo che Gianni abbia fatto un cavolo.
 NEG remember.1SG COMP Gianni have.SBJV.PRS.3SG done a cabbage
 ‘I don’t remember that Gianni did anything.’

(88) shows that *un cavolo* has some ability to convey a sort of (close to) zero interpretation, as similarly observed by Larrivé (2021). This is especially common with predicates expressing worth or value, a context in which vulgar minimisers often present a negative or low-scalar interpretation independently from a negative licenser (Zeijlstra 2018):

- (88) L=ho pagato un cavolo.
 It=have.1SG paid a cabbage
 ‘I paid it a trifle.’

The possibility of these readings suggests that these items are low-scalar endpoints. Thus, the suggestion that UC is an utterance minimiser receives further corroboration: this expression is, abstractly, simply a minimiser. Whether it is used as an indefinite or as an utterance minimiser depends on its structural usage. When it appears in argument or adjunct position, it functions as a vulgar minimiser, while when it modifies an echoic antecedent, its minimising import is predicated at discourse/pragmatic level, to indicate minimal relevance of the utterance.²⁰

5. CC, UC, and the Typology of Peripheral Negators

The features of CC and UC are summarised in Table 1, which illustrates how two apparently similar expressions, which could be rashly grouped under the same heading of ‘metalinguistic’ negator, instead instantiate two very different types of objects:

These features clearly identify UC as a metalinguistic objector, while CC comes out as an emphatic LPN. The only things they have in common (apart from expressing a disagreement/denial of sorts) are (i) high speaker commitment, and (ii) the occurrence of the same lexeme (*cavolo* or its variants). I believe these two commonalities are related, since speaker commitment often associates with the emphatic endpoint-referring quality of minimising expressions (Chierchia 2013).

Where do CC and UC stand with respect to the LPNs described in Section 1? More or less, in the position in which those LPNs stand with respect to each other. For some, a focal position has been proposed (the null negator of *fuck*-inversion, CC, and *no che* sentences are brought together by this feature, though the latter are assumed to participate in a biclausal

²⁰ This observation is in line with the behaviour of other vulgar minimisers which can serve as ‘utterance minimisers’, like German minimiser *ein(en) Dreck*, ‘a dirt’ (Sailer 2018, Erschler 2023: 2):

(i) **Ein-en Dreck** rufe ich zurück.
 a-ACC dirt call.1SG 1SG back
 ‘I won’t call back.’

Table 1. Features of CC and UC

	High speaker commitment (‘emphasis’)	Needs overt antecedent	Polarity licensing	Answer to information- seeking questions	Opacity of the associate	Full-fledged sentential structure
CC	+	–	+	+	–	+
UC	+	+	–	–	+	–

structure), while others are assumed to head their own polar projection (Russian *xuj* and Irish Demonic Negation):

- (89) [FocP **col cavolo** ... [ForceP *che* ... [FinP [PolP [TP ...
- (90) [FocP **no**_i ... [ForceP OP_i *che* ... [FinP [PolP *ci* [Pol° non [TP ...
- (91) [FocP **OP**_[NEG] T_[NEG] +Foc° [FinP [TP *t_i* [PolP **OP**_[NEG] Pol° [FocP fuck Foc° [vP ...
- (92) [PolP **OP**_[NEG]*xuj* **xuj** [FinP [TP [PolP (OP_[NEG]) Pol° [NegP (ne) ...
- (93) [PolP **dheamhan** [FocP (XP) Foc° [FinP [TP ... (**XP**) ...

While as made clear in the previous pages these elements differ in their licensing capabilities, they are all associated with a high commitment on the part of the speaker, which I propose to analyse as the expression of a low degree of strength of sincerity.

As already noted, that the association with the left periphery should be related to a special function or interpretation is not surprising. It was also made with respect to another type of negation which in the literature is assumed to operate on something other than the assertion: expletive negation. It was proposed that expletive negation is not different from truth-conditional negation; rather, it is applied to an implicated, rather than asserted, layer of meaning (Krifka 2010, Delfitto 2013, Delfitto et al. 2019). Greco (2020a, 2020b) in particular makes the case that expletive negation is also left-peripheral, a claim developed in particular for the type of Italian expletive negation he terms Surprise Negation:

- (94) E non mi è scesa da-l treno Maria?!
and EXPL.NEG 1SG.DAT is descended from-the train Maria
‘Mary got off the train!’
[CP E non [FocP [TP mi è scesa dal treno Maria] [Foc°] [... t_{TP} ...]]?!

This mirative negation, Greco proposes, derives its speaker-oriented, emphatic nature from the association with the left periphery, in a dynamic view of syntax in which the interpretation of an operator, including negation, is influenced by or associated with the domain in which it is merged or interpreted. Speaker orientation, or the expression of a certain epistemic attitude, is the thin thread which associates the various types of LPN to the left periphery and between them.

If this is what LPNs have in common, what appears to make the biggest difference among them is whether they associate with the PolP in the lower TP or not. Those which do (*no che*, *fuck-inversion*, *mutatis mutandis* standard negation in Irish and Gbe), by means of movement or agreement chains, are in a sense left-peripheral enrichments, associates, or

manifestations of the sentential negation in the TP-layer, while those which are base-generated and have no association with the lower PolP are 'pure' LPNs, with limited polarity licensing abilities in the lower clause due to non-locality, and yielding double negation with an independent lower negative PolP. CC belongs to the latter category, and I propose that UC belongs to neither, instead representing a type of objector which I call 'utterance minimiser'.

I would like to conclude on a diachronic note. *Un cavolo* (and the original, much coarser *un cazzo*) is barely attested in writing historically due to its vulgar and colloquial nature, but it surfaces profusely in G.G. Belli's (1791–1863) *Sonetti romaneschi* (Belli & Teodonio 1998), which reproduce the speech of the lower classes of Rome. Belli uses *un cazzo* as a vulgar minimiser as in Modern Italian (95), but also as a minimiser in positive contexts (96), and as an emphatic negative adverbial (97)–(98) ((97) is ungrammatical in my contemporary Italian); in this latter use, it could be fronted, thus conveying emphatic negation on its own (99):

- (95) Io sò io, e vvoi nun zete un cazzo.
 1SG am 1SG and 2PL NEG are UC
 'I am who I am, and you are fuck-all.' (362)
- (96) viè a stà un cazzo a la fujjetta.
 come.PRS.3SG to stay UC at the half-litre
 'Half a litre of it costs a trifle.' (122)
- (97) Nun ho mai fatto un cazzo l'assassino.
 NEG have.1SG never done UC the-killer
 'I have never been a killer at all.' (248)
- (98) io nun ce credo *un cavolo*.
 1SG NEG it believe UC
 'I don't believe it at all.' (243)
- (99) ma un cazzo legge lui cuer che cce sta.
 but UC reads he what there is
 'but he does not read what is in there at all' (524)

Belli also uses UC as an utterance minimiser and as a holophrastic rejector:

- (100) Li preti, dichi tu, ssò bburattini! Sò bburattini un cazzo
 the priests say.2SG 2SG are puppets are puppets UC
 'You say priest are puppets; my eye they are' (767)
- (101) Un cazzo: nun è vvero ggnente.
 UC NEG is true nothing
 'My eye: it's not true at all' (2030)

We may hypothesise that the uses as a reinforcing associate of sentential negation functioned as a bridging context for the utterance-minimising interpretation of UC.

As for the minimising origin of CC, there is a further very interesting example by Belli:

- (102) s=arimedia cor cazzo: nun è ggnente.
 IMPRS=remedy.PRS.3SG CC NEG is nothing
 'it takes a trifle to remedy it: it's nothing.' (212)

Crucially, here CC is not yet negative; it rather has a MINIMISING flavour: it means that the situation can be remedied with minimal means. While this is an isolated example, it gives a feel of the original minimising import of CC from which its pragmatic negativisation may have originated.

6. Conclusions

In this paper I discussed two superficially similar expressions in colloquial Italian, *col cavolo* and *un cavolo*. My aim was twofold: primarily, (i) to provide an analysis of the similarities and differences between these expressions, showing that they represent two very different strategies, and secondly (ii) to use the structural analysis of CC and UC as a starting point for a cartography of left-peripheral negators, relating their syntax to the nature of their interpretation and functions.

I argued that CC is a left-peripheral negator which is base-generated in FocP – arguably in a biclausal structure like similar Italian non-verbal predicates – or possibly in Krifka's (2023) Comp, which expresses a zero degree of commitment to the truth of the lower proposition. It is syntactically external to the lower proposition. This explains why it can only license weak PIs for which downward entailment or nonveridicality suffice, while being unable to license strong NPIs or NCIs which require a LOCAL negative operator. On the other hand, UC is what is termed in previous literature a 'metalinguistic negator', a type of objector which I have renamed as 'utterance minimiser'. I argued that this objector use derives from an extension of its function as a vulgar minimiser: when used in a small clause-like equative structure, in which it follows material copied from an antecedent utterance, UC expresses pragmatic minimisation of the antecedent, predicating its discourse irrelevance. This array of facts explains the opaqueness of the antecedent in terms of modifiability or polarity licensing. What brings together CC and UC is the incorporation of the vulgar minimiser *cavolo* and its variants, whose reference to a lower endpoint results in an expression of speaker commitment against the inclusion of the lower proposition (CC) or of antecedent material (UC) in the Common Ground.

Typologically, the most relevant generalisations with respect to LPNs and metalinguistic 'negators' are the following: (i) their use and interpretation is a function of their structural position and derivation: LPNs which are related to the TP-level PolP, either by movement or agreement, are 'amphibious', with the resulting chain having both the features of sentential negation (also in terms of polarity licensing abilities) and the high commitment/discourse-managing function typical of LPNs. Those which are base-generated in the left periphery, on the other hand, have limited polarity licensing capabilities and yield double negation with a lower expression of negative polarity: they are native left-peripheral objects and hence non-local to the lower material. (ii) Metalinguistic 'negators' (or at least a subset of them) like UC, *una ova*, *una mierda*, etc., are completely different objects which function as utterance minimisers, participating in an equative structure which predicates minimal conversational/informational worth of a previous utterance (or part thereof).

This analysis is based on a selection of relatively well-attested expressions. Hopefully, future research will expand this picture, further verifying the present generalisation that the structural position and derivational history of LPNs – and the original scalar semantics of utterance minimisers – allow a mapping of their semantic-pragmatic interpretation to their internal composition and external syntax.

Acknowledgements. This paper is a heavily reworked version of the contents and analysis of Chapter 1, Part II of my doctoral dissertation (D'Antuono 2024b). It is also, I believe, a considerably improved one, which I owe in no small part to the dedication of the editors and to the careful, insightful, and constructive comments of three anonymous reviewers for *JL* (who are not to be held responsible for any shortcomings). This research was partly funded by the PRIN Research Grant n. 20222JEN3B of the Italian Ministry of University and Research, 'An integrated approach to negation: Core syntactic processes, lexical structure, and linguistic microvariation', which is hereby gratefully acknowledged.

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